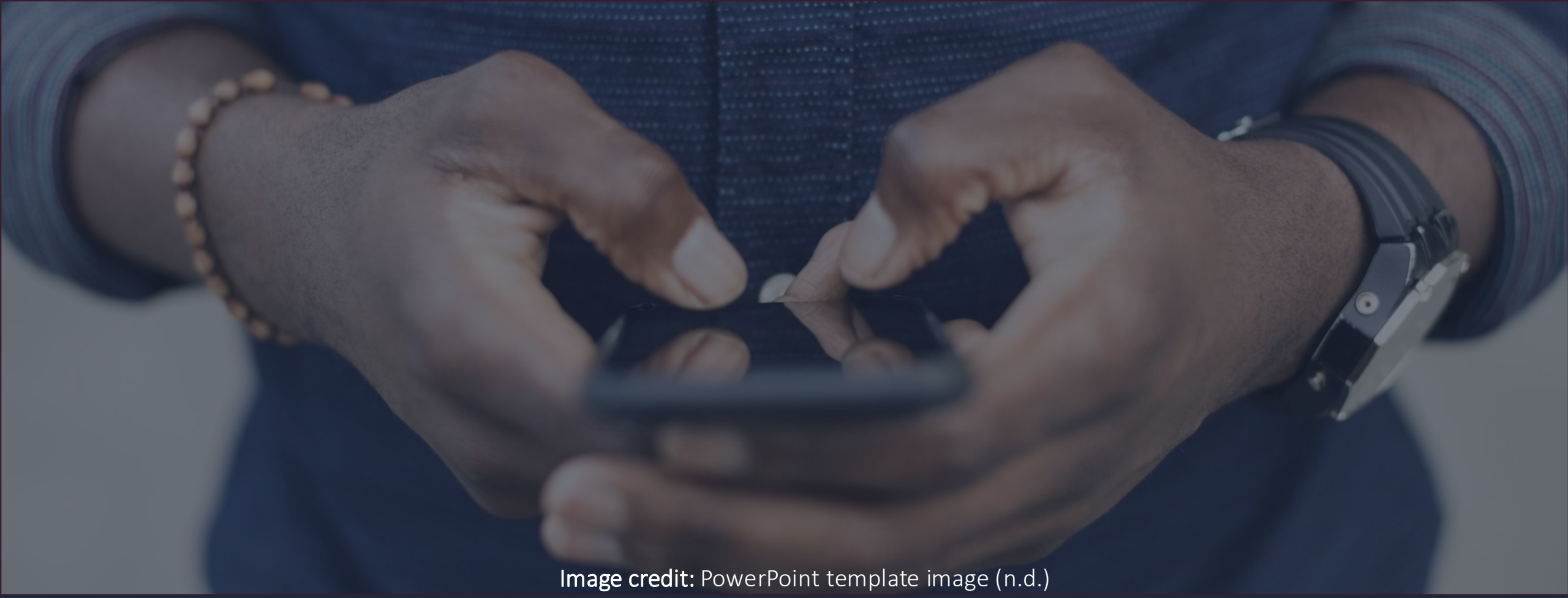

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PRIVACY CONCERNS IN TECHNOLOGY

BY ODO MICHAEL CHUKWUEMEKA

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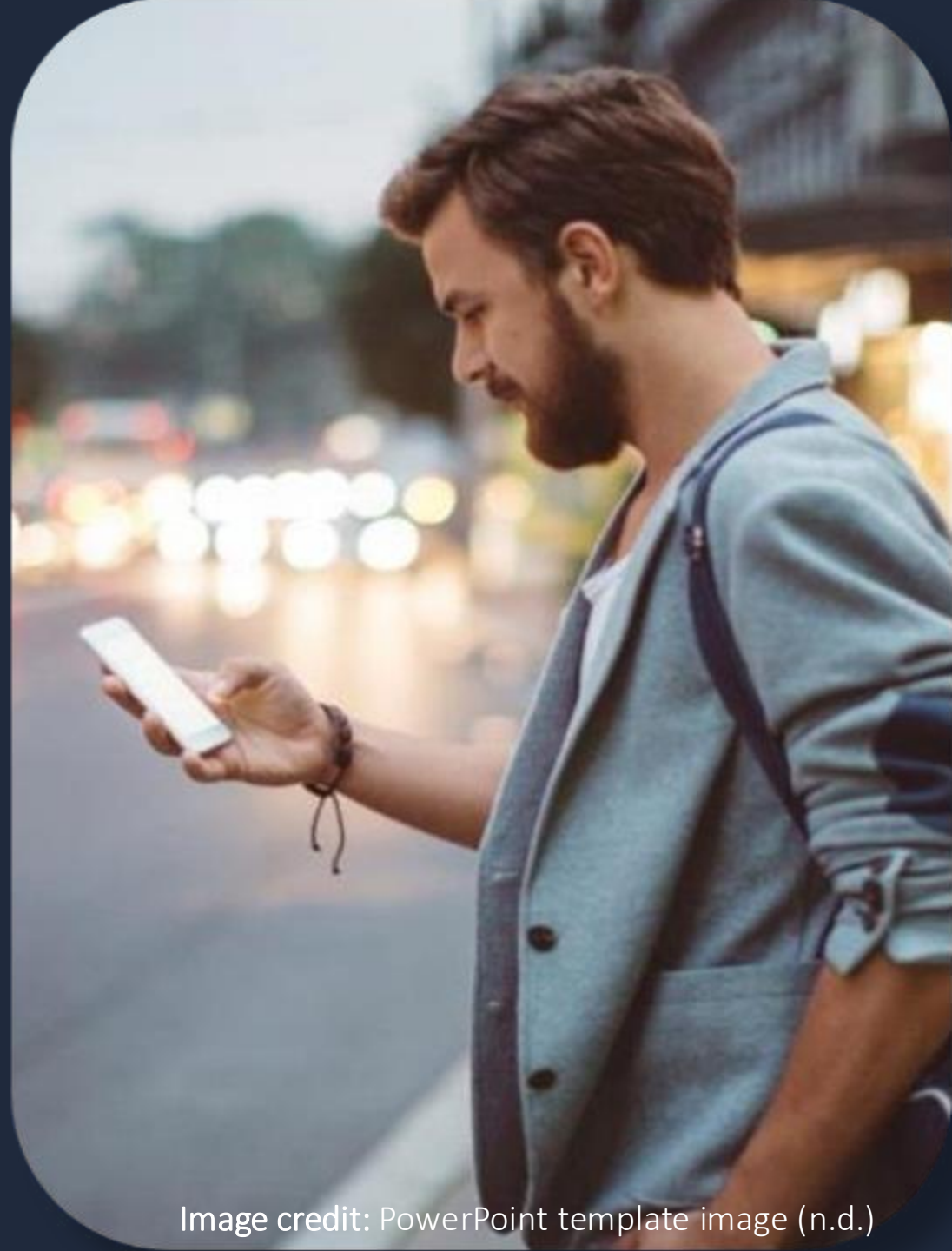
What's Privacy

Privacy in technology refers to an individual's right to control how their personal information is collected, used, stored, and shared by digital systems, devices, and online platforms.

Privacy is a critical concern for individuals and organizations across the globe(Mohammadi et al., 2019) As technology advances and data collection becomes pervasive, the design of privacy policies has gained significant importance (Ghazinour & Albalawi, 2016).

Accordingly, the concerns people have about privacy are often vague and ill-formed, which makes it correspondingly difficult to address these concerns, and to explain the ways in which technologies do or do not pose threats to people's interests. (Elliott, D., & Soifer, E. 2022).



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Why Privacy Matters

- Privacy is a basic right that everyone should have.
- Modern technology collects a lot of information about us.
- If this information is misused, it can lead to things like identity theft, spying, or unfair treatment.
- People will only trust technology if their personal information is properly protected.

Image credit: PowerPoint template image (n.d.)

Real-World Examples
(e.g., case studies, news stories, industry reports).

Pause before you post campaign Awareness Campaign by DPCI

The video shows how online privacy risks can affect a real family. By posting on social media, Éabha's parents accidentally shared personal details like her name, age, birthday, friends, football club, training times, and even that her dad is sometimes late picking her up information that strangers could use against her. (Data Protection Commission Ireland, 2025)

Image credit: Data Protection Commission Ireland (n.d.)

Please let's watch for just 50secs Link: https://youtu.be/4QL1FmBaof8

Real-World Examples
(e.g., case studies, news stories, industry reports).

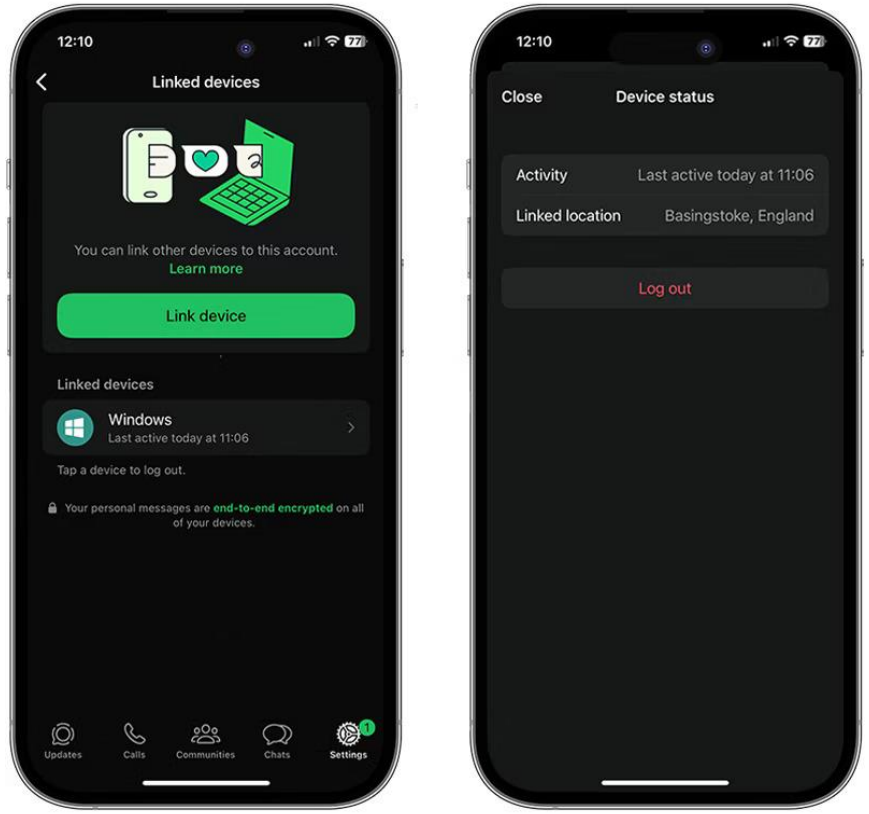

Image credit: Certo Software (2024)

Abusers exploited Whatsapp Account linked feature.

When WhatsApp first introduced the “linked devices” feature, it didn’t require any authentication. This meant anyone could scan your QR code and instantly access your WhatsApp chats and contacts.

I experienced this in college when a friend linked my account without my knowledge and used it to beg people for money. Although I eventually logged out all linked devices, he had already collected money from some of my contacts.

Real-World Examples
(e.g., case studies, news stories, industry reports).

Character. AI investigation

Texas AG vs. The "Therapist" Bot

In 2024/2025, the Texas Attorney General investigated AI platforms like Character.AI because chatbots allegedly tricked users, including minors, into thinking their chats were private and therapeutic.

In reality, these conversations were reportedly used to train AI and target ads, exploiting users' trust and emotions for profit. (White & Case LLP, 2025).

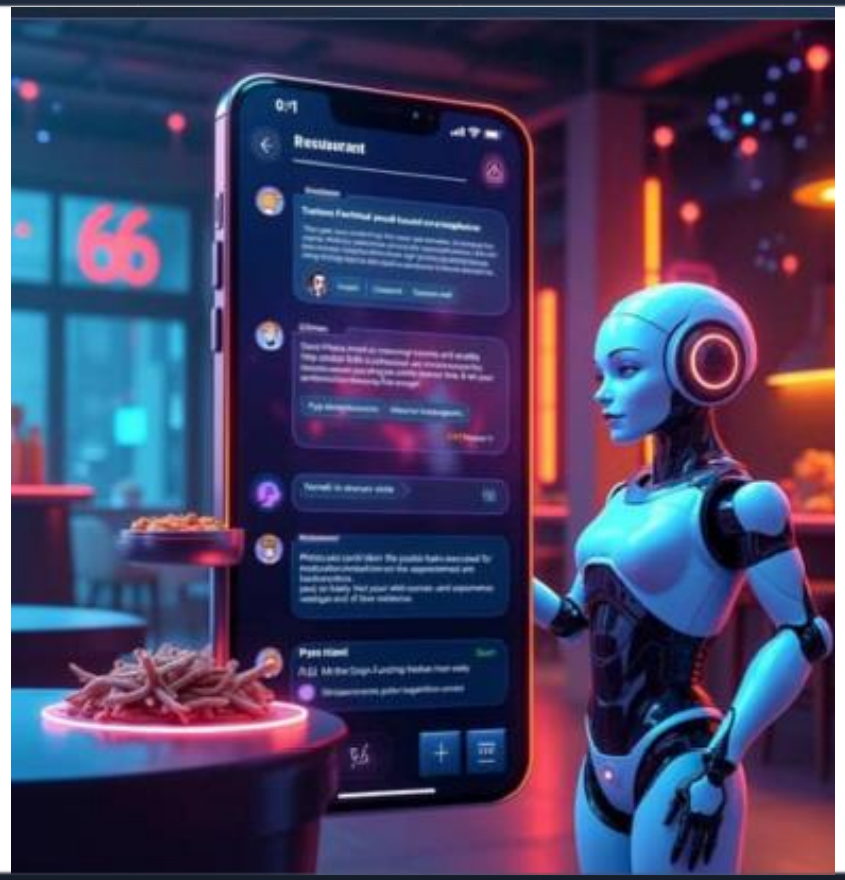

Image credit: easy-peasy.ai (2024).

Benefits of Data Collection

- **Personalized services:** Helps companies show you ads and content that match your interests.
- **Better fraud detection:** Makes it easier to spot and stop scams or security threats.
- **Creates job opportunities:** Data-related roles increase employment in tech and other industries.
- **Boosts company revenue:** Companies can make more money by using data to create new products and improve user experience .
- **Improved healthcare:** Devices and apps collect real-time health data that warns doctors and individuals about problems early, before they become serious.

Image credit: PowerPoint template image (n.d.)

Risks of Data Collection

- **Cyberattacks and scams:** Hackers can steal or manipulate personal information.
- **Loss of control:** People may not fully understand or agree to how their data is used.
- **Data sold or shared secretly:** Information can be passed to third parties without the user knowing.
- **Discrimination:** Data can be used unfairly to judge or exclude certain groups of people.
- **Surveillance:** Governments or companies may track people's activities too closely.

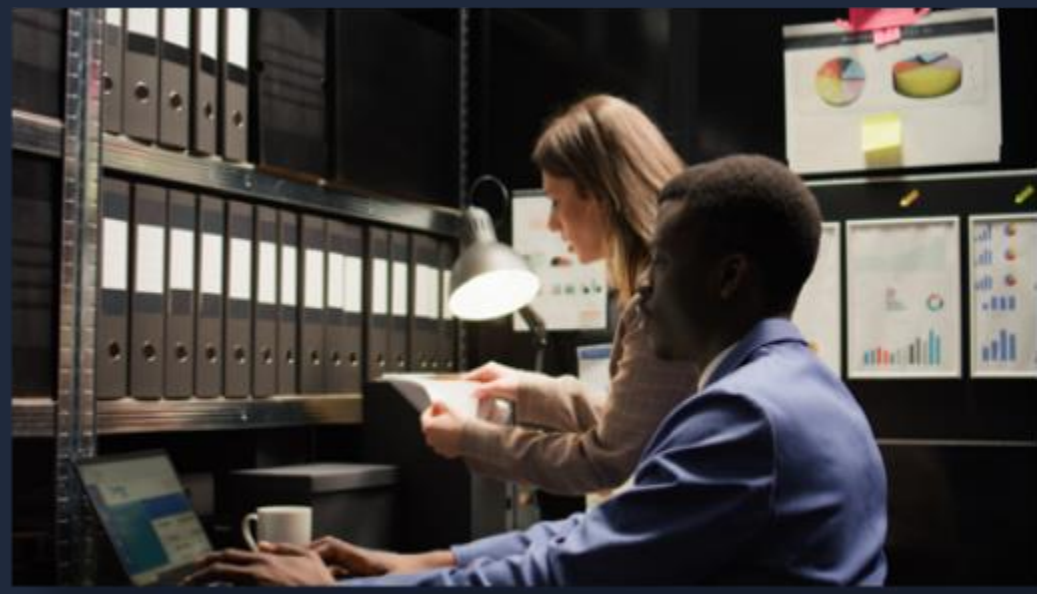

Image credit: Freepik

Path Forward: Ethical Solutions

Stronger Data Protection Laws

Governments should create strict rules (like GDPR) to make sure companies protect people's personal information properly.

Be Transparent About Data Collection

Companies must clearly tell people:
what data they are collecting,
why they are collecting it,
how it will be used.
No hidden tricks.

Build ethical and safe AI from the start

When creating apps or AI systems, developers should design them with privacy built-in from the beginning, not as an afterthought.

Path Forward: Ethical Solutions

Give Users Control Over Their Data

People should be able to choose:
whether they want their data collected (opt-in),
or not (opt-out).
And they should be able to delete their data anytime.

Customer Data Insurance

Companies can offer insurance to protect customers if their data is stolen or leaked.
This builds trust and reduces damage during data breaches.

Use secure technologies (RFID & HITAM)

RFID helps safely track and protect sensitive information in devices.
HITAM helps developers understand user concerns so they can build safer, easier-to-use security features.

Abbreviations

AI	Artificial Intelligence
DPCI	Data Protection Commission Ireland
GDPR	General Data Protection Regulation
RFID	Radio Frequency Identification
HITAM	Information Technology Acceptance Model

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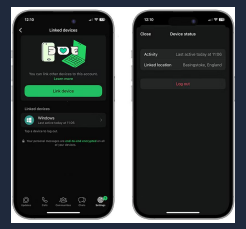

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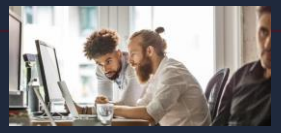
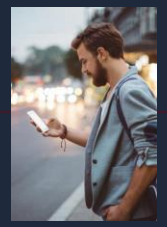

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